

***THE PLAY OF THE WEATHER* IN PERFORMANCE in the Great Hall at Hampton Court**

Eleanor Rycroft

‘Staging the Henrician Court’

On 4–8 August 2009, an experimental performance of John Heywood’s *The Play of the Weather* took place in the Great Hall of Hampton Court Palace. The production formed one of the research outputs of the two-year AHRC-funded project ‘Staging the Henrician Court’; a collaboration between the Universities of Oxford Brookes and Edinburgh, Historic Royal Palaces, and theatre professionals, to consider the question of how drama reflected and informed the organisation and marshalling of space at the court of Henry VIII. A film of the performance of 5 August 2009 is available to view until 2020 on the project website at www.stagingthehenriciancourt.org, along with historical images and intertexts selected to illuminate the play, the notion of courtly space, and the historical context of early Tudor drama. The project website also includes articles on key research topics written by the ‘Staging the Henrician Court’ research team including Professors Thomas Betteridge and Greg Walker.

The project is the latest Tudor Great Hall drama to be revived through performance following the staging of a number of interludes during the 1980s and 1990s, such as John Marshall’s production of *Wisdom* at Winchester Cathedral in 1981, the University of Salford Arts Unit’s version of part two of Medwall’s *Nature* in 1984, the performances of the *Poculi Ludique Societas* in Canada, and the numerous productions of the *Joculatores Lancastrienses*, including Meg Twycross’ *Fulgens and Lucre*s at Christ’s College, Cambridge, and *Apius and Virginia*, also at Cambridge, in the Old Hall of Queen’s College.¹ Such productions become rich sources of potential information about the historical interrelationship between space and theatre, with Avril Henry reporting, for instance, that the splendid setting of Winchester Cathedral meant that ‘no props or staging’ were required for *Wisdom*, and Peter Meredith arguing that the serious debate of *Fulgens and Lucre*s ‘seemed to be what the hall was made for’ at Christ’s College.² However, the number of discoveries that were made through practice-based research were matched by the number of questions

raised by it, with Meredith less convinced by A's entry through the audience in *Fulgens and Lucres*, for example, and Boffey, Cowen, and King uncertain about the interpolation of a rap in *Apus and Virginia*.³ These differences of opinion are partly the product of the gap between historical knowledge, textual interpretation, and creative endeavour which are the crux of any practice-based research project. As similar problems were encountered during 'Staging the Henrician Court', I should like to reflect on these issues with relation to performing *The Play of the Weather* at Hampton Court.

The text and the court

The choice of the Great Hall at Hampton Court Palace as the performance venue for *The Play of the Weather* was made on the basis of it being the only surviving example of a Great Hall built by Henry VIII. The play could not have been originally performed there, because construction work on the Hall was not completed until 1535, and Heywood's text was published by William Rastell in 1533. To add to the uncertainty about the original performance space, no Revels accounts survive from 1528–1534, the precise period during which the play was written and performed, and, even if they were available, interludes are frequently absent from a historical record which favours the pageant or masque over the seemingly more lowly form of the dramatic dialogue.

We cannot definitively know, therefore, whether *The Play of the Weather* was performed at the court of Henry VIII, although internal evidence such as the courtly appointment of the play's Vice, Merry Report, by Jupiter, as well as a stateliness of tone throughout the piece, supports a courtly performance context. In *Plays of Persuasion*, Greg Walker has located the play among the sub-genre of early Tudor dining hall drama on account of its references to the torch-bearers who illuminated the hall at night (line 98), and The Boy's reference to an evening banquet hosted by 'my lorde' (line 1027), but also largely on the basis of its relation to Heywood's other drama that was clearly intended for performance at court.⁴ Merry Report evidently enters the space from among and between the members of the audience, in line with the dramaturgical conventions of hall drama,⁵ and Jupiter selects his officer from among a number of extant courtly personnel, much like the courtiers who were available for official appointments at Henry's court, as shown in the Eltham Ordinances concern that 'able, meete, honest and sufficient persons' should replace those officers who are deemed to be failing in their duties in 1526: 'the

sicklie, impotent, inable, and unmeete persons, as of rascals and vagabonds, now spred, remaining and being in all the court'.⁶

While the *débat* dramaturgy of the play⁷ may also point towards Inns of Court auspices, it became very apparent during the staging of the play that courtliness governed its structure. There are clearly moments in the play which privilege the spatial organisation and etiquette of the court above other concerns, particularly in terms of the evocation of audience sympathy on the basis of who might be considered a court 'insider' rather than on the basis of nobility of status. Many of the characters represented in *The Play of the Weather* derive their semantic value in the play according to their relationship (or not) to the court. By performing the play, it became clear that the text overwhelmingly sympathises with the characters perceived to have courtly affiliations as service providers: The Ranger and The Laundress for instance, or The Boy who might perform either as a chorister in the Chapel Royal or as a member of the household's theatrical troupe.

Of course the attribution of pathos to these characters was an interpretative choice, but nevertheless Heywood consistently favours characters engaged in occupations essential to the operations and maintenance of the court, over a ruling class frequently represented as idle, ostentatious, or self-interested. The Ranger may be debarred access to Jupiter because of his low status, but this peripheral figure of the court is handled more carefully by Merry Report than is The Gentleman who brings too large a retinue to the 'god's court' to have properly heeded the exhortation in the Eltham Ordinances, 'that no Lord spirituall nor temporall, nor other nobleman or personage, of what estate, degree or condition soever he be, lodged within the court, or not lodged within the court, doe bring with him into the same any greater number of servants'.⁸ Merry Report acidly remarks on 'all [the] meyny' (222)⁹ that comprise the Gentleman's entourage, ironises the notion of the Gentleman having a 'job' (233), and then subjects him to a barrage of bawdy jokes relating to both his wife and fundament. While it could be assumed that high-status characters might attract the most sympathy in court drama, the text repeatedly calls attention to a distinction between those who choose weather necessary to perform the vital, if menial, occupations that maintain courtly order — The Ranger or The Laundress for example — and those who choose weather for their recreation — The Gentleman and The Gentlewoman, both of whom initially display attitudes, behaviours, and a lack of knowledge of courtly protocol which displace them from the centre

of the *curia regis*. While *The Merchant and the Millers* are also charged with discourtesy by Merry Report,¹⁰ the failure to know whom to address (Merry Report directs *The Gentleman* to speak only to him and 'let the reste alone'; 221) or how to proceed (*The Gentlewoman* does not know what to 'do where so mych people is'; 767) is a striking and surprising facet of the noble characters' entrances, suggesting that perhaps they are representatives of a regional aristocracy rather than worldly members of the royal household.

Methodology and collaboration

Such intricacies were revealed during an initial rehearsal process which took place in January 2009, six months before the second rehearsal period and the staging of *The Play of the Weather* at Hampton Court in August. This decision to divide the rehearsal process into two stages was made to facilitate further research into particular areas which had arisen as a result of the January rehearsal. However, we also resolved upon a research 'signing-off' point in May, when the project creative team was scheduled to take over completely, and the academic advisors retired from making their contributions to the project. The need for elucidation of various aspects of the text, early English theatre, and political history, demonstrated that rehearsal was a valid research methodology in itself, pointing up textual features or references which required further study in order to locate the range of meaning in the play. The rehearsal and staging of a play draws attention to aspects of the text that can easily be glossed over in a reading. When blocking *The Play of the Weather*, for example, it was startling how much quibbling took place over the correct use of courtly protocol in determining the spatial relations between the suitors and Jupiter; Merry Report approaching too 'ny' (101) to Jupiter when putting himself forward for the job being only the first instance of a number of breaches of conduct throughout the play.¹¹ The Ranger, for instance, attempts to bypass Merry Report's mediating role in the granting of an audience with the god (438–9) and *The Gentlewoman* impertinently requests to be let in 'the backe syde' (770) to sue to Jupiter, instigating a ribald response from 'god's officer'. The intrinsic difficulties that arise from Merry Report's management of the unruly suitors are elusive on the page, but the imperatives of blocking bring to the fore the three-dimensional spatial relationships between characters, of particular importance to this play.

Courtly space and relations lay at the heart of the project. A speculative workshop had taken place in 2008 which helped the team to refine its research objectives. These were crystallised into two specific research questions: (1) in what ways does staging John Heywood's *The Play of the Weather* utilise and/or transform the space of the Great Hall and (2) To what extent did Henrician drama create courtly space? However, necessarily, some aspects of the original staging were foregrounded and others relegated at an early stage in the process. For instance — and although this remained a matter of academic debate before, during, and after the performance — it was decided early on that we would not have a substitute 'Henry' in the Great Hall when the play was performed. Several factors influenced this decision, including the fact that this aspect had already been explored during the initial workshop of 2008. The notional Henry had certainly restricted the actors' movement, whose performances were limited by having to play down a central axis towards Henry's gaze. However, this also undermined their ability to play towards the audience and, while the Great Hall is a courtly space, the early Tudor interlude also explicitly calls for audience interaction. The exhortation in the text for the blurring of audience and actor was felt to be at variance with a performance directed towards the dais end of the Hall. In addition, gesturing towards the presence of Henry was seen to be necessarily provisional. While it might give the audience a sense of majesty, it could only nominally approximate how the drama of the court was transformed by the presence of Henry VIII.

Audience feedback was divided on the choice not to stage a monarchical spectator of early Tudor interludes, with some feeling that it was a major flaw in the production, and others feeling that the unpopulated high table became a sort of absent *presence* which was as effective as someone actually sitting at the high end of the Hall. Moreover, recent contemporary scholarship challenges the assumption that Henry would have attended the interlude drama that was performed at court. A recent article by Jeanne McCarthy addresses the disparity between the kinds of theatrical involvement of Henry VII and those of his son, contending that Henry VIII was far more interested in 'lavish court-enacted entertainments'¹² than with the secular household drama preferred by his father. Arguing against Greg Walker, she writes that, 'Ultimately, if the "Henrician period ... was one in which drama 'mattered'", evidence now hints that it did not seem to matter all that much to the King'¹³ and that, rather than the literary drama of the period requiring the audience of

the monarch, 'Drama thrived largely in the King's absence'.¹⁴ Scholarly dubiety over this area did not detract however from the sense that this was certainly a play *about* and *for* the court, even if it did not require the presence of the King, as has previously been assumed.

A concern that the project would not be able to reconstruct courtly ambience in its every detail also influenced the decision not to cast male actors in the female rôles. Having experimented with an all-male performance of the Merry Report/Gentlewoman scene in 2008, the research team decided that this was a variable that the experiment could exclude from the full-length production. Any practice-based research project of this nature has to decide what the central areas of interest are; and all-male performance, like the presence of the monarch, was again felt to have dramatic effects which could not be fully reconstructed by a modern production or understood by a modern audience. The decision was not reached easily however, and, as we prepared for the final phase of the project — two workshop performances of scenes of the play in the Great Hall on 4 and 6 March 2010 — the question of whether we should cast the play with male actors was again debated.

Production decisions were made alongside the theatrical practitioners with whom the project team collaborated. Such collaborations come with clear advantages, namely the organisation, efficiency, and professionalism of the parties engaged and the quality of the finished products of set, costume, and original musical composition. However, it must be also admitted that they can also have disadvantages for a research project of this nature. Contemporary theatre is arguably a conservative institution and truly collaborative approaches are rarely found in the professional industry due to its organisational structure. Negotiating scholarly contributions in the rehearsal room could therefore be fraught; too many interventions can undermine the director's normative experience of how he or she stages a play, as well as their command over the actors. Theatre professionals might also bring their own sets of assumptions to the rehearsal room. So, while the talented professional actor who played Merry Report coped with the technical difficulties of a Heywoodian text (such as the fragmentation of prosody and the complexity of the Vice's alliterative list of place names), the current imperative to realise the character's psychological 'journey' arguably constrained his performance. The theatre practitioners justifiably concluded on the basis of the rehearsal process that Merry Report did not display the mischievous elements with which he is charged by being nominated a 'Vice' on the title page. In fact

he performs his duties for Jupiter according to the letter, and is shown to be an effective and committed officer to the god — with Jupiter acknowledging this in the lines, ‘Son, thou haste ben dylygent and done so well | That thy labour is ryght myche thanke worthy’ (1123–4). And yet, such a performance clearly goes against some obvious textual cues that theatre historians are trained to decipher — one not very sublimated example being his name. Merry Report should have been more ‘merry’. In the March workshops of 2010 we tried to redress this by using the same actor, but by asking him to take the folly and comedy in the text to greater extremes.

When collaborating with theatre professionals, scholars must leave space for their creative interpretation. In terms of costume, therefore, our designer’s imagination was not sparked by the research team’s excavations of the Loseley Papers, and Feuillerat’s transcriptions of the Revels accounts, but research into, for instance, *Holbein in England*, *The Tudor Tailor*, *A Visual History of Costume — The Sixteenth Century*, *Costumes of the Greeks and Romans*, as well as the visual inspiration of images of Henry VIII and the Abraham tapestries in the Great Hall. A significant discovery which was made during study of Feuillerat did not influence the costume design and yet is worthy of note. Tucked in the back of his transcription of Marian and Edwardian revels accounts is an undated document specifically ‘concernyng a Enterlued’¹⁵ which refers to a costume painted with buckets. Does this record pertain to Heywood’s Laundress? While it is impossible to determine for what performance this costume was intended (the pervasive problem of research into Tudor dramatic apparel generally), it was also potentially a significant finding for the project. Yet allegorical costumes were not popular among the creative team, and at points a deferral to their telling of the story had to also be made, especially as the project was not largely concerned with the question of historical authenticity. Compromises must be reached in these sorts of collaboration, and the ‘Staging the Henrician Court’ approach was not to impose a defined set of staging requirements prior to the rehearsal period, but to see the rehearsal process as a valid way of reaching collaborative decisions about what would and would not be privileged in the final production, which could then be researched further in the period between January and August 2009.

On the other side of the collaboration lay the project team’s relationship with Historic Royal Palaces, who were always generous and accommodating with regard to the project, despite their own very tangible

concerns and responsibility to preserve the Great Hall at Hampton Court for future generations. Nevertheless some decisions had to be modified in accordance with conservation regulations, especially in terms of producing the film of the play.¹⁶ Both limits on funding and the exigency to protect the features of the Great Hall forced us also to jettison an initial idea concerning Jupiter's throne. Influenced by how many magical appearances and disappearances govern entrances and exits in the early Tudor pageant, for instance the vanishing of the king, lords and ladies into the castle of 'le Fortresse dangerus' at Greenwich on New Year's Eve, 1511/2,¹⁷ we had hoped to create a false wall that mimicked the screen at the lower end of the Great Hall, behind which we would secrete Jupiter before the performance. The empty throne would be open to the view of the audience as they were being seated, but as the curtain of his tent briefly fell, the actor playing Jupiter would relocate from behind the false wall to the throne so that, when the curtain was re-raised, Jupiter's descent from heaven at the play's opening would appear to have occurred before the audience's very eyes. The exigency not to have any scenery touch the actual screen, as well as the sheer expense of the venture, however, precluded this from happening.

Case studies: Audience and Lighting

While not all of the historical research could be realised in performance either as a result of collaboration compromise, conservation concerns, or funding limitations, the project successfully incorporated ideas found in the historical record into the production which addressed the specific research questions of 'Staging the Henrician Court'. Two of these, the arrangement of the audience and lighting, made hypotheses about the utilisation and transformation of courtly space through drama, as well as how far drama created the court.

Seating arrangements were deemed key to the notion of space for the Tudor interlude. Theatre historians agree that audiences were subject to some sort of formal organisation, either arranged hierarchically, or in familial or occupational groupings, or by gender. There appears to be a requirement in the text for a similar sort of division in *The Play of the Weather* with Merry Report identifying the 'sort' of women out of whom The Gentleman may hunt a 'sow or twain' (249). There is also historical precedent for the division of the audience in this way, with Lodovico Spinelli recording an audience organised along lines of rank and gender for the performance of *Love and Riches* during the Greenwich revels of 5 May

1527, writing that there were three tiers of seats along the sides of the hall occupied by ambassadors, princes, and 'those to whom admission was granted, they being few' and that 'On the opposite side, in the same order were the ladies'.¹⁸ Other ways of segregating the audience for the August production were considered; along lines of academic eminence, for instance, or along lines of age, with the most distinguished or eldest nearest to the dais end of the Hall. However, these were not only felt to be sensitive distinctions, but the demands of a text which appears to call for an audience division on the basis of gender were heeded. It was also felt to be an inherently courtly distinction, conferring upon the performance space the gender dynamic which was prevalent in aristocratic households, as well as in a society at large in which men and women were often segregated. The aim was to make the audience feel in some ways as estranged and subject to the gaze of other audience members as the original audience might have been. Forum feedback on the project website suggested that this was certainly the case, with Claire Shuttleworth commenting that the seating felt alien for a twenty-first century audience member and that, 'its effect was to make you very aware of your gendered identity through the performance from looking at — and being looked back at — by the opposite sex the whole way through the performance'.¹⁹

In terms of utilising and transforming the Great Hall then, drama contributed to the transformation of a notionally egalitarian space in which food was probably served to members of the court twice a day, into a mirror for and of the élite and the patterning of personnel which was so crucial to courtly rank and order. To the extent that Henrician drama created courtly space, our version of *The Play of the Weather* both reflected and produced a court in which a distinction between genders was a part of everyday Tudor culture, and in which communion between aristocratic males and females was as ritualised as the courtly ceremonies, including the interludes, masques, and pageants, where it is recorded.

Another significant constituent element of courtly power and space which emerged during the research period of November 2008 – August 2009 was lighting. Cavendish, for instance, frequently alludes to the cupboards of plate whose magnificence was augmented by the use of candles at the household of Wolsey. Of the visit of the French ambassadors to Hampton Court in 1527, he writes, 'The plates that hung on the walls to give lights in the chamber were of silver and gilt, with lights burning in them and a great fire in the chimney, and all other things necessary for the furniture of so noble a feast'.²⁰ The importance of

lighting techniques for the study of the early Tudor theatre has been the focus of a number of recent academic investigations, not least Professor Martin White's 'Chamber of Demonstrations' project at Bristol University.²¹

Lighting thus became a critical issue over the course of the project. The Christmas revels of 1532/3 emerged as a plausible dating for the play's original performance during the January rehearsal period on the basis of this being a transitional phase during Henry's reign when Catherine of Aragon had been exiled from court, but Anne Boleyn was not officially yet the Queen (despite being in the early stages of her pregnancy with Elizabeth). Such a dating clarifies the so-called 'new moon speech' in the play (793–817) as offering a piece of news to the court through the medium of theatre; conveying to them in an informal mode that the old queen or moon is officially 'out' and that the newer, tighter one is being fashioned (the making of moons not being an activity with which Jupiter is associated). However, it also meant that the early August, dusky light which illuminated the 2009 performance was incorrect for the seasonal performance conditions of the original production. It seemed necessary to explore what effect low-level lighting would have both on *The Play of the Weather* and on audience reception, so this became a research focus of the March workshops of 2010.

Hanging lights on 'branches' strung on wires across the width of the Hall was dismissed on the grounds of both funding and conservation, and the use of real candles was obviously proscribed because of the danger these posed to the Great Hall, notably the priceless Abraham tapestries. Electric alternatives therefore had to be found; not ideal, because of their modernity, but the only option. As with the August production, the 106' x 40' space of the Great Hall was narrowed and reduced in length by our seating arrangement. This involved having tables with benches on either side (to signify a banquet) arrayed along the sides of the Hall, to the extent of the articulated dais. These had to be set at least one metre from the wall in line with Hampton Court conservation rules. For the March workshops the performance space was shortened even further by having a row of tables running parallel to the dais but approximately three metres in front of the hearth. Essentially, what had been a traverse stage in August became a thrust stage in March as the performance space was reduced. Through this staging arrangement we hoped to evoke what we viewed as the intimacy²² of the household interlude, despite the regal auspices. To indicate the use of candles and plate described in Cavendish, metal plates

were mounted on wooden stands before which were set small electric bulbs in the attempt to magnify the light reflected by the bulb. In addition, two actors were employed as 'torch-bearers', with even smaller halogen bulbs attached to the end of half-metre long wooden sticks, which the torchbearers used during the performance to provide extra light for the actors.

The torchbearers in particular raised many interesting questions relating to courtly performance. If light is associated with power in monarch's palaces — with more candles used to illuminate Henry VIII than any other member of the court — how does torch-bearing in the drama affect the status of actors who are temporarily afforded more light? Merry Report's line, 'Brother, hold up your torch a little higher' gestures as much towards his social aspirations as it does his need to be seen by Jupiter, and light, like costume, can be seen as usurpation of cultural power on the part of the player. At the level of staging, there were also significant difficulties when blocking the interactions between actor and torchbearer. How did torchbearers and actors interrelate in hall drama? Did the former aim to remain invisible, or did they become a part of the spectacle? It seemed that a considerable amount of choreography was required to make this feature of early modern performance work in practice. The role of torch-bearing in the early Tudor drama certainly emerged as an area in which there is more practice-based research to be conducted.

Conclusion:

Because of the methodological approach of the 'Staging the Henrician Court' project, it is only with the benefit of hindsight that the strengths and weaknesses of the project can be assessed. The performance was intended to be a research output that stimulated debate about the parameters of dramatic performance in Tudor hall venues and the relationship between courtly space and Henrician policy, rather than to definitively resolve how interludes were staged at the court of Henry VIII. The August 2009 production was a hypothesis; a staging which privileged some dramaturgical elements above others as a means primarily to open up questions about how the grandiose space of Hampton Court's Great Hall was transformed by virtue of dramatic performance. A key finding was that the foregrounding of spatial etiquette in the historical record is mirrored by a drama in which the placement of actors in three-dimensional space is fraught not only textually but in practice. Another significant finding was that the play's representations of estates was not structured

along lines of high- vs. low-born characters, as with interludes such as *Of Gentleness and Nobility*, but largely along lines of those who operated internally to the court, and those that were figured as outside of its (dramatically represented) concerns — which strengthened the argument that this was a play performed at the court of Henry VIII, though not necessarily directly for him.

Feedback following the production and via the forum of the project website came largely from the specialists in late medieval and early Tudor performance: Meg Twycross (Lancaster University and Joculatores Lancastrienses), for instance; Sarah Carpenter (University of Edinburgh); Peter Cockett (McMaster University); and Frank Whately (Kingston University). They not only contributed useful practical comments on staging issues, informed by direct experience, but also critical reflections and insights, informed by knowledge of record sources and the history of early English theatre.²³ Professor Twycross, for example, raised the important question of whether we could have foregrounded the mythological dimension to the text, by heeding Merry Report's reference to a costume which was seen to invoke the wings of Mercury, being either 'fryse or fethers' (134),²⁴ as well as the potential detriment to the production of not using the boy actors who might have highlighted the playful or satirical representations of femininity in the text. One very useful suggestion made by Professor Twycross was that the rather monotonous and linguistically unwieldy opening monologue by Jupiter might have been accompanied by a masque which depicted the discord and subsequent unity of the gods and goddesses being described. Such a performance would have been provided visual interest and is certainly in line with what we deemed to be the 'pageant-like' top and tail of the play which seemed at variance with the Estates satire and comic interlude of its body.

Perhaps this is a direction that can be followed by future producers of *The Play of the Weather*. Other production choices which were eschewed included allegorical costume design, the serving of food during the performance, and the performance of the play as a part of a day-long sequence of events in line with the sorts of Henrician entertainments outlined in historic documents; too obtrusive for a busy tourist attraction such as Hampton Court. Practice-based research consistently generates more questions and possibilities than it can hope to resolve, but even disagreement over the 'Staging the Henrician Court' version of *The Play of the Weather* is a desirable outcome in terms of suggesting alternatives or

testing the assumptions of spectators. In the words of Jupiter, 'All wethers in all places yf men all tymes myght hyer' (1187), then the result would be chaos. Partiality is both the instantiating discourse for the play and what it warns against, serving as a useful analogue for collaborative, practice-based theatre research of this nature.

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NOTES

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1. Avril Henry 'Wisdom at Winchester Cathedral, 21–23 May 1981' *METH* 3:1 (1981) 53–5; David Mills 'Part Two of Medwall's *Nature*' *METH* 6:1, 40–42; Peter Meredith 'Medwall's *Fulgens and Lucre*' *METH* 6:1 (1984) 44–8; Julia Boffey, Janet Cowen, and Pamela King '*Apus and Virginia*' *METH* 13 (1991) 112–13. As productions reviewed in *METH*, these are the ones that have given rise to documented academic discussion. For a general discussion of 'Modern Productions of Medieval English Drama' see John McKinnell's chapter in *The Cambridge Companion to Medieval English Theatre* edited Richard Beadle and Alan Fletcher (Cambridge UP, 2008) 287–325.
2. *METH* 3:1 53; *METH* 6:1 48.
3. *METH* 6:1 45; *METH* 13 112.
4. Greg Walker *Plays of Persuasion: Drama and Politics at the Court of Henry VIII* (Cambridge University Press, 1991) 133–4. The identification of *Weather* as hall drama was also made by David Bevington who writes that the play, 'Like *Fulgens and Lucrece* ... is an interlude to enliven a patrician evening banquet'; *Tudor Drama and Politics: A Critical Approach to Topical Meaning* (Cambridge, Mass: Harvard UP, 1968) 65.
5. T.W. Craik was among the first to illuminate the references to the 'place' in interludes and to identify these Tudor plays as designed for indoor performance; *The Tudor Interlude: Stage, Costume and Acting* (New York: The Humanities Press, 1958) 10. Peter Happé writes that Craik 'gave attention to aspects of performance, the central concept being that interludes were indoor plays which relied firstly on *place* for performance but operated by establishing

- an intimacy with the audience. This was constantly renewed by such devices as direct address, or planting actors among the audience (as in *Fulgens and Lucrez*); *Cambridge Companion to Medieval English Theatre* edited Beadle and Fletcher, 329.
6. *A Collection of Ordinances and Regulations for the Government of the Royal Household, Made in Divers Reigns. From King Edward III to King William and Queen Mary. Also Receipts in Ancient Cookery* edited Society of Antiquaries (London: White and others for the Society, 1790) 146.
 7. Epitomised by the humanist argument conducted between the Millers of *The Play of the Weather* in a scene reminiscent of the oral debates by which the rhetorical skill of student lawyers was tested in order for degrees to be conferred.
 8. *A Collection of Ordinances* 149.
 9. All references to the play are taken from John Heywood 'The Play of the Weather' in *Medieval Drama: An Anthology* edited Greg Walker (Oxford: Blackwell, 2000).
 10. The Merchant disappears while Merry Report is suing on his behalf to Jupiter (343), while The Water Miller is said to 'rudely ... erre from rewlz of curtesye' (473) and to have not gone through the proper channels when entering the Court (487).
 11. The Merchant, also, whose concerns are in many ways represented as antithetical to the court, somehow disappears between his request to see Jupiter and the granting of that request, to Merry Report's chagrin: 'Why, where be you? Shall I not fynde ye?' (343).
 12. Jeanne H. McCarthy 'The Emergence of Henrician Drama "in the Kynges absens"' *English Literary Renaissance* 39:2 (2009) 231–66, 233.
 13. McCarthy 'Emergence of Henrician Drama' 233.
 14. McCarthy 'Emergence of Henrician Drama' 234.
 15. Albert Feuillerat *Documents relating to the Revels at Court in the Time of King Edward VI and Queen Mary* (Materialien zur Kunde des älteren Englischen Dramas 44; Vaduz: Kraus, 1963, reprint of Louvain: Uystpruyt, 1914) 245.
 16. See the film director Richard Jack's article, 'Filming in the Great Hall at Hampton Court' in the 'Resources' section of the project website at www.stagingthehenriciancourt.org.
 17. Janette Dillon *Performance and Spectacle in Hall's Chronicle* (London: Society for Theatre Research, 2002) 43.
 18. 'Venice: May 1527' *Calendar of State Papers Relating to English Affairs in the Archives of Venice* edited Rawdon Brown and others, 38 vols (London: HMSO, 1871) 4 (1527–1533) 59.

19. For this statement and further discussion of audience arrangement for the 'Staging the Henrician Court' *Play of the Weather*, including the instances when audience and spectator relations were blurred in our performance, please see the key research topic 'Audience' on the project website, www.stagingthehenriciancourt.com.
20. George Cavendish 'The Life and Death of Cardinal Wolsey' in *Two Early Tudor Lives* edited Richard S. Sylvester and Davis P. Harding (New Haven and London: Yale University Press, 1962) 73.
21. E.g. Robert B. Graves *Lighting the Shakespearean Stage, 1567-1642* (Carbondale: Southern Illinois University Press, 1999). Professor White's research is documented on the website 'The Chamber of Demonstrations' www.bristol.ac.uk/drama/jacobean.
22. The word 'domestic' was avoided because it signified a category of familial belonging that was deemed inappropriate to describe the fundamentally hierarchical nature of the court.
23. The forum has been archived on the project website and all the debates stimulated by the August 2009 production can be found in the resources section.
24. There is, in fact, evidence that *Weather* may bear some relation to John Rastell's 1527 'Father of Heaven' pageant at Greenwich, in which disputes between Chapel children players were 'judged by the King on the authority of Jupiter'. In this entertainment, Mercury wore a 'blue taffeta gown sewn all over with eyes' (rather like the costume covered in buckets) which Axton and Happé suggest might have influenced Heywood's costume for Merry Report; *The Plays of John Heywood* (Cambridge: Brewer, 1991) 48. Their note on Merry Report's new livery following his appointment links his potentially mythological costume with a 1548 inventory at St. John's College, Cambridge which lists the items among which are a 'starr gilted for Mercury's hedd / A golden face and crowne for Jupiter' (290).